



Part I: Communications Principles



1. Communications Is an Art

Description

This activity explains that communications is much more of an art than a science. There is no one right or wrong way to communicate—no set of absolute rules to be followed.

Time Guideline

20 minutes

Purpose

To emphasize to participants that each of us communicates in our own style and in ways most comfortable and effective for each of us. Like art, communications can take on unlimited forms and variations, each unique to the person engaged in the communications.

Resources

Handout 1-A

Presentation

1. Present Handout 1-A to participants.
2. Ask participants if they agree or disagree with this statement and why.
3. Explain that communications does have certain principles and procedures (see other activities in Part I of this book). There are specific, sound principles and themes, but thousands of variations.
4. However, there is no right or wrong way to communicate effectively.
5. Everyone has their own communications style, and there are thousands and thousands of variations to effective communications. What is most important is that people communicate in a sincere and honest manner with one another, in a style in which they are most comfortable. Few if any people can communicate effectively in a manner or style that does not fit them personally or naturally.

Debrief

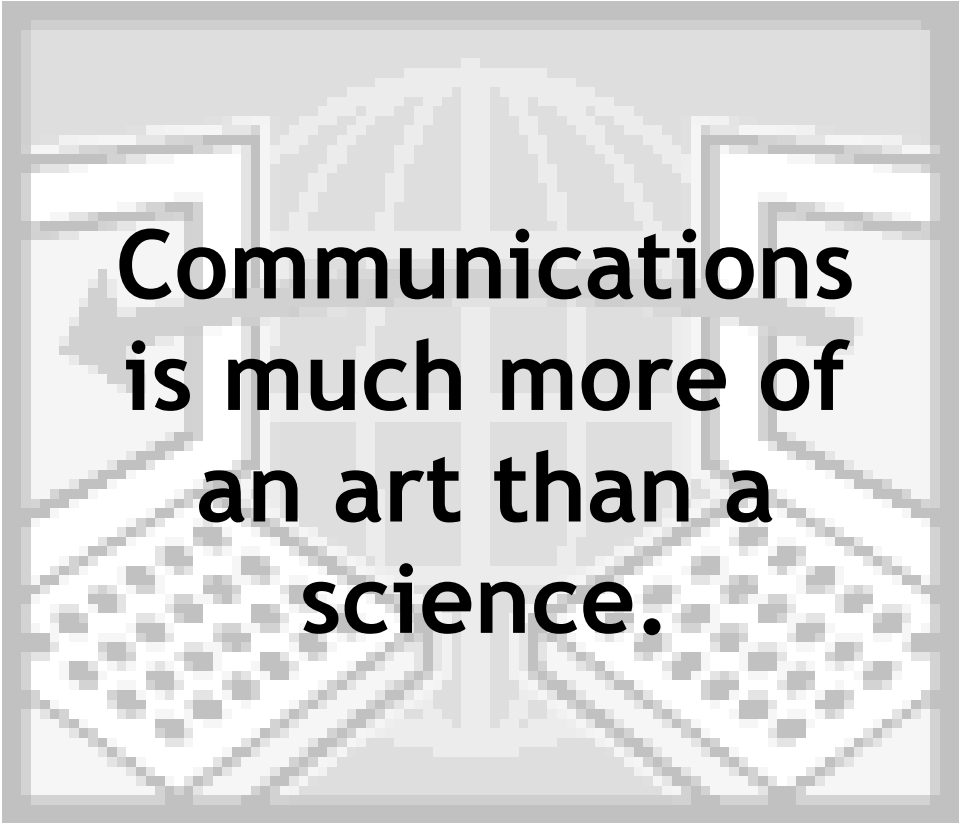
Ask participants if they have ever tried to communicate in a manner or style that was not natural to them, and, if so, how difficult was it to do this effectively.

Difficulty Rating

Low

Variations

Before showing or sharing Handout 1-A, ask participants if they believe communications is more an art or a science. If you hear the response from participants that they think communications is more of a science, ask them why they feel this way. Ask them what would define something as a science. Expect to hear comments that use terms such as *consistent*, *exacting*, etc. Ask if they feel that communications could really be defined in this way.



**Communications
is much more of
an art than a
science.**

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2. Communicating Time

Description	The amount of time we spend communicating with others is presented in this activity.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To highlight the great amount of time we actually spend communicating with others
Resources	Handout 2-A
Presentation	1. Ask participants how much time they think they actually spend communicating with others. 2. Allow the group to provide their estimates. Write the estimates on a flip chart or piece of paper. 3. Present Handout 2-A. Emphasize the statistics presented in this handout: 70% of your total waking time is spent communicating in some manner. Of this time you spend communicating, you spend approximately 16% reading, 9% writing, 30% talking, and 45% listening. 4. Ask participants if they are surprised by these estimates of the average time that people spend communicating, especially the 45% listening statistic. 5. Point out that these percentages may vary from person to person. For example, some people may spend much more than 30% of their communications time talking and much less time listening!
Debrief	Explain that looking at these statistics, it makes even more sense that we should strive to constantly become better communicators. Our communications skills play an important part in our success and even happiness in life. Ask participants to think about how much communications time they actually spend on each of the

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communications activities described in this activity. Ask them how changing these balances of time in each of these communications could make a difference in their lives.

Difficulty Rating

Low to medium

Variations

Encourage participants to set goals for changing the amount of time in each of these communications activities and to establish objectives they might hope to accomplish as a result. Ask participants if they believe that their relationships with other people could be improved as a result and how.

How do we spend our communications time?

We spend approximately 70% of our time communicating with others.

Of this communications time, we spend:

 16% Reading	 9% Writing
 30% Talking	 45% Listening

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3. Communications Is the Key

Description	This activity consists of an interactive discussion about the importance of communications in the workplace.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To highlight the importance of communications in solving problems at work
Resources	Handout 3-A
Presentation	1. Present Handout 3-A, which states the following: Communications is the key to achieving all of our goals. 2. Ask participants if they agree or disagree with this statement. You can expect that all or most participants will agree with this statement. 3. Ask participants why they believe this is true. Expect participants to volunteer any number of reasons. 4. Ask participants if they can think of a situation or problem in which communications was not critically important. 5. Challenge participants to thoroughly explain how better communications would not be necessary to correct the situation or problem.
Debrief	Emphasize again that communications affects virtually everything that happens in organizations. Communications can be one of the greatest strengths of an organization or one of its biggest weaknesses. Ask participants to specifically discuss how communications is important in their jobs.
Difficulty Rating	Low

Variations

Ask participants to share situations, problems, and challenges at work in which communications played a critical role, both in the cause and solution.



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4. I Know You Believe You Understand

Description	A quote is presented to participants, and they are asked to explain what they believe its meaning is.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To highlight how unclear communications can lead to confusing interpretations and to emphasize the need for clarity when communicating
Resources	Handout 4-A
Presentation	1. Present Handout 4-A to participants and ask them what they think the statement means. 2. Expect participants to have differing interpretations, if any, of this very confusing statement. 3. There obviously is not a clear explanation for this statement. Apparently, this speaker was trying to say something about being misunderstood, but it is unclear what he or she was really trying to say. 4. Reveal the source of this quote and expect comments from participants about trying to communicate with a government agency or official to resolve a problem or to cut through government red tape.
Debrief	Discuss what problems are created by these types of communications. Emphasize how much confusion ambiguous communications like this can cause in an organization. Ask participants to remember this quote when they are communicating with others as an example of how important clarity of communication is to being understood.

50 Communications Activities, Icebreakers, and Exercises

Difficulty Rating

Low to medium

Variations

Use your own choice of a confusing quote or ask participants to share some confusing quotes they know of.



“I know that you believe you understand what you think I said, but I am not sure you realize that what you heard is not what I meant!”

– Quote from a U.S. government official

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5. Communications Model

Description	A communications model is presented to help participants better understand what actually needs to occur for effective communications to exist.
Time Guideline	30 minutes
Purpose	To provide a conceptual model for participants to follow to help them become better communicators
Resources	Handout 5-A
Presentation	1. Present Handout 5-A and explain that this represents a model showing how effective communications can be achieved. Although this may seem like a cumbersome process to go through, this model is used in some manner by many people in all of their communications. 2. Go through the four steps shown in the model. Highlight that in this model there is a SENDER and a RECEIVER. 3. Start with the SENDER, and point out that the first step in the communications process involves the SENDER sending the message to the RECEIVER. Explain that even at this early step in the process, many problems can occur. For instance, the message may not be clearly communicated by the SENDER. This could be a function of the SENDER's communication skills or even the effort that this person puts forth to communicate clearly. 4. The second step involves the RECEIVER both hearing and responding to the message. There can be problems with both. The RECEIVER may not be able to clearly hear the message for any number of reasons, including distracting sounds or competition for his or her attention. Also part of this step is the RECEIVER responding to the message. Of

course, this can't be done if he or she doesn't hear the message or chooses not to respond. In either case, the message would end at this point and often does.

5. The third step goes back to the SENDER to clarify anything that the RECEIVER may have misinterpreted in the message. This gives the SENDER another chance to make sure his or her message was heard correctly and to clarify anything that may have been misinterpreted.
6. The fourth and last step involves the RECEIVER confirming that he or she now understands the message, and the process is complete.
7. Explain that following these four steps helps ensure that there is no misunderstanding concerning the message the SENDER intended to communicate and what the RECEIVER heard.

Debrief

Explain that this model provides a communications format that could be followed in any number of different ways. Although it may not be practical to formally go through each of these steps in the model in every communication you have with others, ensuring that these concepts are used in some manner can help participants become better communicators. This is particularly important to ensure that the message is clearly communicated and understood.

Tell the story about the supervisor who would ask employees to repeat back to him what he just said to them. By doing this, he taught his employees to be better listeners. They listened carefully to everything he instructed because they knew he would ask them to repeat what he said back to him.

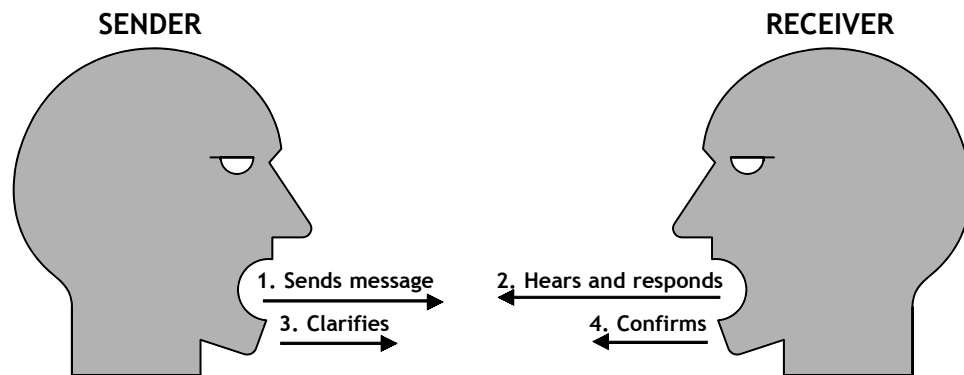
Difficulty Rating

Medium to high

Variations

Have volunteer participants demonstrate how to use this model in a role play.

An Effective Communications Model



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6. Listening Dilemma

Description	Interesting facts are presented concerning the rate of words that we are able to hear versus the rate at which we speak and the dilemma this presents.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To help participants understand why listening is such a big challenge for most people
Resources	Handout 6-A
Presentation	1. Distribute or present Handout 6-A to participants. 2. Explain that listening is a big challenge because you spend so much of your communications time listening—over 45%. If you are not a good listener, you will be a less effective communicator. 3. Explain that the average person speaks at about a rate of 150 words per minute (wpm). The problem is that we can hear at about a rate of 1,000 wpm. This obviously gives us a lot of extra time. 4. Ask participants what they do with this extra time. It is likely that they will say that they think about other things rather than what the other person is saying. 5. This is a big problem for many people and the reason why they are not good listeners. This creates the listening dilemma.
Debrief	Discuss with participants some things they could do to stay focused on what the other person is saying and not be distracted by their own thoughts. For instance, the following listening tips can help you be a better listener:

1. Concentrate on what the speaker is saying, both with his or her words as well as with voice inflections, rate of speech, body language, etc. There are many things that can influence these communications, and paying attention to as many as you possibly can will help keep you focused.
2. Try not to think about how you are going to respond to the other person while he or she is speaking to you. This will cause you to lose your concentration on what the other person is saying.
3. Interact nonverbally with the other person with small gestures or verbal affirmations, such as nodding your head or saying very brief comments such as “I see” or other words that would not interrupt the other person. This tells the other person that you are fully engaged in listening and also keeps you involved in the process.
4. Do not interrupt or finish the other person’s sentences. This takes your concentration completely away from what the other person is saying and focuses your attention on your own words.

Difficulty Rating

Low

Variations

After reviewing these four listening tips, have participants practice listening to each other while trying to focus totally on the other person’s words without being distracted. Have participants break up into pairs and take turns being the communicator and listener. Instruct each communicator to speak for about two to three minutes while their partner listens. Suggest that they describe their job duties to each other. After completing this exercise, discuss as a group how successful participants were totally concentrating on the other person’s words and not being distracted.

The Listening Dilemma

- We speak at a rate of about 150 words per minute (wpm).
- But we can hear at a rate of about 1,000 wpm.



- This gives us a lot of extra time!
- What do we do with this time?

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7. Interactive Listening Tips

Description	Five interactive listening tips are presented to help participants learn to become better listeners.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To provide a quick and easy-to-remember list of suggestions to help participants become better listeners
Resources	Handout 7-A
Presentation	1. Distribute or present Handout 7-A. 2. Review these listening tips: a) Paraphrase the message to the speaker in order to confirm your understanding. <i>Explain that by putting the message in your own words, you concentrate more on what was said, making you listen better.</i> b) Repeat the message to help you remember what was said. <i>Explain that by doing this to the other person's satisfaction that you have heard his or her message correctly, you ensure that you not only are listening but really understand what was said.</i> c) Probe for missing information. <i>Explain that by requesting or asking questions, you find out any information that may have been missing in the communications or that you need or want.</i> d) Clarify any points that you might not completely understand. <i>Explain that this also ensures that you have heard exactly what the other person intended to communicate.</i>

- e) **Remember** the important points of the message for future application.

Explain that this helps you retain the most important points of the communication.

Debrief

Ask participants how often they use these tips in their communications with others. It is likely that they use some or all of these tips on a regular basis, probably without being aware that they are using the tips. Ask participants how they could use them more often and what effect this would have on their listening skills.

Difficulty Rating

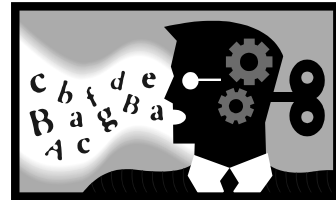
Low

Variations

Ask participants to share listening tips of their own with the group.

Listening Tips

- **Paraphrase** the message to the speaker in order to confirm your understanding.
- **Repeat** the message to help you remember what was said.
- **Probe** for missing information.
- **Clarify** any points that you might not completely understand.
- **Remember** the important points of the message for future application.





8. Listening Bad Habits

Description	A list of listening bad habits is presented for participants to evaluate their listening skills.
Time Guideline	30 minutes
Purpose	To help participants better understand areas in which they can improve their listening deficiencies
Resources	Handout 8-A
Presentation	1. Distribute Handout 8-A to participants and ask them to complete it. 2. Explain that each participant will use this list of listening bad habits to honestly evaluate his or her listening skills or lack thereof. 3. Explain that participants are to check the bad habits they may be sometimes guilty of committing when communicating with others. 4. Emphasize that most people have some problems being good listeners and these bad habits are not unusual for people to demonstrate.
Debrief	Emphasize again that most people are, at least from time to time, guilty of many or most of these listening bad habits. The most important thing is to be aware of your tendency to fall into these bad habits and consciously try to avoid making these mistakes. Tell participants not to be too hard on themselves if they check many or even all of these bad habits. It is all part of human nature!
Difficulty Rating	Medium to high
Variations	Ask participants what other listening bad habits they can think of and share with the group.



Listening Bad Habits

Following is a list of ten bad habits of listening. Check those listening bad habits that you are sometimes guilty of committing when communicating with others. Be honest with yourself!

- ☐ I interrupt often or try to finish the other person's sentences.
- ☐ I jump to conclusions.
- ☐ I am often overly parental and answer with advice, even when not requested.
- ☐ I make up my mind before I have all the information.
- ☐ I am a compulsive note taker.
- ☐ I don't give any response afterward, even if I say I will.
- ☐ I am impatient.
- ☐ I lose my temper when hearing things I don't agree with.
- ☐ I try to change the subject to something that relates to my own experiences.
- ☐ I think more about my reply while the other person is speaking than what he or she is saying.

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9. Listening Questionnaire

Description	A listening test is presented to participants to measure their effectiveness as listeners.
Time Guideline	30 minutes
Purpose	To help participants better understand their weaknesses and strengths as listeners
Resources	Handouts 9-A and 9-B
Presentation	1. Distribute Handout 9-A to participants. 2. Ask participants to evaluate their listening skills. 3. Tell participants to write the number in the column that most accurately describes their listening skills for each of the seven statements. 4. Point out that the best score for each statement is 5, indicating that the participant never has that particular listening problem. 5. Give participants about 5 minutes to complete the questionnaire. 6. After participants have completed the questionnaire, display the scoring key in Handout 9-B. 7. Have participants total the number of points for the seven statements. A perfect score is 35 points. 8. Ask if anyone had a perfect score. 9. Review the scoring ranges for being an <i>effective listener</i>, <i>good listener</i>, and <i>not-so-good listener</i>, and if anyone scores less than 13 points, their listening skills might be best described as HUH?

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Debrief

This exercise and the results should be fun and not taken too seriously. The purpose of the exercise is to allow participants to give some thought as to how they can specifically improve their listening skills. The statements are all phrased in the negative to point out many of the most common problems that people have listening.

Difficulty Rating

Low to medium

Variations

Ask participants to rate someone else whom they have difficulty communicating with concerning his or her listening skills. The purpose would be to better understand that person's listening skills and think about how best to communicate with this individual given these results.



Listening Questionnaire

When listening to another person, I...	Always (1 pt.)	Usually (2 pts.)	Often (3 pts.)	Rarely (4 pts.)	Never (5 pts.)
Get distracted					
Listen only to facts					
Interrupt					
Assume the other person already knows					
Prejudge					
Tune out					
Ignore nonverbal clues					
Total	+	+	+	+	=

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Listening Questionnaire Scoring

31–35 points = Effective listener

21–30 points = Good listener

14–20 points = Not-so-good listener

13 points or less = Huh?

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10. Seven Levels of Listening

Description	Seven levels of listening, from the lowest level to the highest, are presented.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To illustrate that there are different levels of listening that can determine how effectively you communicate with others
Resources	Handout 10-A
Presentation	1. Distribute Handout 10-A and review the seven levels of listening. 2. Point out that each involves greater levels of involvement and commitment to listening on the part of the listener. 3. Give examples of each type of listening from your own experiences. For instance, ask participants if they have ever experienced level 1 or level 2 listening when someone just was not listening to them when they had something to say. Or ask if they have ever been given only part of someone's attention when trying to communicate with another person. Ask participants how that made them feel. 4. Explain that levels 5 through 7 require higher, more involved listening skills. Explain that the last three levels of listening involve not just hearing the words but trying to understand the meaning behind them from the other person's perspective as well as your own. 5. Explain that level 5, interpretive listening, involves really trying to hear not only the person's words but the feelings and emotions of the communication.

6. Level 6, interactive listening, involves becoming part of the communications process. It involves asking clarifying questions and acknowledging understanding of the other person's words and emotions being conveyed.
7. Level 7, engaged listening, involves not only hearing and understanding the other person but also expressing your feelings and emotions as well. Explain, however, that truly engaged listening doesn't compete with the other person's desire to communicate his or her feelings. In engaged listening, each person provides the other the opportunity to fully express himself or herself.

Debrief

Explain that not every communication with others is the same and at the same level. The level of listening involved should be appropriate for the situation. Even some of the first levels of listening may be appropriate given the situation.

Ask participants if they can think of a situation in which this might be true. For example, often when waiting for some form of transportation, such as at an airport, you might only listen for information concerning your own flight and tune out the rest of the information you might hear.

There are other times when all you need to do is focus and understand the other person's message, and interacting or interpreting is not appropriate or necessary for the situation. An example might be when receiving directions from someone.

Ask participants if they can think of other examples in which each of these levels of listening may be the most appropriate.

Difficulty Rating

Medium to high

Variations

Ask participants to role play or demonstrate for each other these different levels of listening.

Seven Levels of Listening

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|---|
| 1. Not listening: | Not paying attention to or ignoring the other person's communications |
| 2. Pretend listening: | Acting like or giving the impression that you are paying attention to another person's communications, but in actuality not really paying attention to that individual |
| 3. Partially listening: | Only focusing on part of the other person's communication or only giving it your divided attention |
| 4. Focused listening: | Giving the other person your undivided attention to his or her communication |
| 5. Interpretive listening: | Going beyond just paying attention but really trying to understand what the other person is communicating |
| 6. Interactive listening: | Being involved in the communications by asking clarifying questions or acknowledging understanding of the communication |
| 7. Engaged listening: | Being fully engaged in communications involves listening to the other person's views, feelings, interpretations, values, etc., concerning the communication and sharing yours as well with the other person(s). In engaged listening, both parties are given the opportunity to fully express their views, feelings, and ideas. |

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11. Silent Messages

Description	The concept of what happens when one doesn't communicate or say anything is explored in this activity.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To explain that not communicating sometimes sends a stronger message than if you did say something
Resources	None
Presentation	1. Explain that many times when we think we are not communicating we are actually sending a very strong message. These are the "silent" messages that sometimes get inadvertently sent to others. 2. Make the point that often when we say "nothing" we are actually saying a lot. 3. Being silent and not saying anything may actually be sending a strong message to others. This is particularly true for supervisors, managers, or anyone in a position of authority. For example, if you see inappropriate or unproductive behaviors by employees and don't say or do anything to correct the situation, you are actually saying a great deal. Your lack of communications could be misinterpreted as condoning these behaviors. This may be completely opposite of your intent. 4. Ask participants to provide examples of these silent messages.
Debrief	Conclude the activity by emphasizing that especially individuals in leadership positions must be conscious of the fact that if they don't say anything when behaviors need to be corrected or complimented that unintended messages may be sent. We need to be careful about these "silent messages."

50 Communications Activities, Icebreakers, and Exercises

Difficulty Rating

Low to medium

Variations

Give others examples of your own concerning how lack of comment or communications can give the wrong message to others.



12. The Three Levels of Communications

Description	This activity presents statistics relating to the way we receive communications and the true messages being sent by others.
Time Guideline	30 minutes
Purpose	To help participants understand what an important part nonverbal behaviors and voice inflections play in how we both send and receive messages
Resources	Handouts 12-A and 12-B
Presentation	1. Introduce the activity by explaining that when we communicate face-to-face with others, we receive messages on three basic levels: <i>vocabulary</i>, <i>voice inflections</i>, and <i>nonverbal behaviors</i>. Distribute or present Handout 12-A. 2. Explain that vocabulary messages consist of the actual words we use to communicate with others. 3. Explain that voice inflections consist of the way that someone says something. This would include tone, speed, emotions, pace, volume, etc. The way someone says something can dramatically change the meaning of the words being spoken. 4. Finally explain that nonverbal behaviors include the body language, facial expressions, gestures, etc., that someone might use while communicating with others. 5. Ask participants which of these three factors—vocabulary, voice inflections, or nonverbal behaviors—is most important. In other words, which is most influential in sending a message from one person to another?

6. Distribute or present Handout 12-B. Explain that studies have shown that
 - 7% of what we communicate is based on vocabulary;
 - 38% of what we communicate is based on voice inflections; and
 - 55% of what we communicate is based on nonverbal behaviors.
7. Ask participants if these statistics surprise them.
8. Explain that so much of the messages we get from others is from their nonverbal behaviors. Ask participants to share their perception of what nonverbal behaviors are. Explain that nonverbal behavior is also called body language. You don't have to be an expert to learn to read other people's body language such as crossed arms, a defensive posture, or even facial expressions. Ask participants if they ever had the experience of knowing what someone was going to say by his or her body language before he or she even began talking.
9. Explain that 38% of a message is sent via a person's voice inflections. Explain that voice inflections are how you say things. The very same word or words said another way with different voice inflections could take on an entirely different meaning. For example, ask a participant to say the word *no* with a voice inflection indicating doubt. Ask another participant to say this same word with a voice inflection indicating a definitive negative answer. Comment on the dramatic difference in meaning between these two different interpretations of the way this same two-letter word was just spoken.
10. Ask participants what they think happens on the telephone to voice inflections. The answer is that because there are no nonverbal cues to observe, the influence of voice inflections dramatically goes up, accounting for 88% of the message being sent to the person on the other end of the phone.

11. Finally, point out that there is only 7% left for the actual words themselves. The actual words themselves account for such a small percentage of the total because there can be so many different interpretations of a message based on such things as nonverbal behaviors or voice inflections that may not have been initially intended. This is why it is so important to pay close attention not only to *what* is being said, but *how* something is being said, because this is where the true meaning of the communication can be found.

Debrief

Explain to participants that to become more effective communicators they need to pay attention to these three levels of communications when communicating with others. By becoming more conscious and even in control of the way you say things, you can help ensure that you are being understood by others. We need to be careful in our communications not to send what is often called “mixed messages” to others. A mixed message in this sense is when the actual words being spoken are not consistent with the speaker’s voice inflections and/or body language. This confuses others and makes them unsure of what was the real message being sent. You will notice that the most effective communicators present a consistent message concerning these three levels of communications.

Difficulty Rating

Medium to high

Variations

Demonstrate examples of where these three levels of communications are inconsistent. Make a statement but say it in such a way that your voice inflections and nonverbal behaviors are not consistent with the message. For example, you might say, “I am really very excited about being here,” however, say this in a monotone, low voice, lacking any enthusiasm. In addition, cross your arms with your head down and a disgusted look on your face. Ask participants what the real message was in your communication and how it was different than the words you spoke.



The Three Levels of Communications

1. Vocabulary
2. Voice Inflections
3. Nonverbal Behavior

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How We Really Communicate

- 7% of what we communicate is based on vocabulary
- 38% of what we communicate is based on voice inflections
- 55% of what we communicate is based on nonverbal behaviors

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13. Nonverbal Listening Test

Description	A brief test is presented to help participants better understand the importance of nonverbal communications.
Time Guideline	30 minutes
Purpose	To emphasize how critical it is to be aware of nonverbal communications in our interactions with others
Resources	Handout 13-A Pen or pencil for each participant
Presentation	1. Distribute Handout 13-A to participants. 2. Introduce the activity as a test of participants' understanding of nonverbal communications. 3. Instruct participants to spend the next 5 minutes completing this brief test. 4. Allow participants time to complete the test. 5. After everyone has completed the test, review the suggested correct answers. Ask participants to correct their own tests if they have marked the wrong answers.

Answers

- 1) Communications other than the actual words spoken; includes all forms of body language, eye contact, and other cues that one might send that give indications of what the person is really communicating
- 2) Examples: smiling, maintaining eye contact, arms unfolded
- 3) Examples: frowning, avoiding eye contact, arms crossed
- 4) (1) Eye contact, (2) Body posturing, (3) Position of arms and hands

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- 5) 7%
- 6) Less voice inflections and emotion in voice;
makes understanding what the person is
saying harder to understand
- 7) The ability of a speaker to use inflections and
pitch
- 8) He or she is ready to listen to you attentively.
- 9) The person may not be in agreement.
- 10) True

Debrief

Discuss differences participants may have had
with these recommended correct answers.
Explain that with nonverbal communications
there may be many different interpretations of
what is really meant.

Difficulty Rating

Medium to high

Variations

Present the test as a group exercise.



Nonverbal Listening Test

Answer as many of the following questions as you can in the next 5 minutes.

1. What does the term *nonverbal communications* mean?

2. Give three examples of positive nonverbal communications:

1)

2)

3)

3. Give three examples of negative nonverbal communications:

1)

2)

3)

4. Rank order from most influential to least the following forms of nonverbal communications as the best indications of what a person may actually be communicating to you:

_____ Body posturing

_____ Position of arms and hands

_____ Eye contact

5. How much of the meaning of a spoken statement comes from the actual words spoken? (check one)

- ☐ a) 75%
- ☐ b) 7%
- ☐ c) 20%

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Handout 13-A (concluded)

6. If someone speaks in a monotone, what does this mean and what influence does this have on his or her communications?

7. "Vocal variety" means which of the following? (check one)

- ☐ a) Traveling comedy shows of the 1920s
- ☐ b) The ability of a speaker to use inflections and pitch
- ☐ c) The ability of the speaker to use breathing techniques and do impersonations

8. During a meeting between you and a coworker, he or she moves a chair from behind the desk and asks you to sit down to discuss something. You could interpret this nonverbal communication to mean: (check one)

- ☐ a) He or she is trying to conclude this meeting quickly.
- ☐ b) He or she is distracted.
- ☐ c) He or she is ready to listen to you attentively.

9. When a person crosses his or her arms during a conversation, this is an indication that: (check one)

- ☐ a) The person may not be in agreement.
- ☐ b) The person is totally supportive of the other person's views and opinions.

10. Nonverbal communication skills are important to be a good communicator. (check one)

- ☐ a) True
- ☐ b) False

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14. The Laws of Remembering

Description	This activity involves introducing participants to the Laws of Remembering, which consist of four principles concerning how we remember things.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To provide tips to participants to help them remember information better
Resources	Handout 14-A
Presentation	1. Present Handout 14-A to participants. Introduce the Laws of Remembering, which can help participants become better at remembering. 2. Review each of these principles. 3. First, explain to participants that we remember best what we heard last or heard most recently. This is why we often repeat the most important part of the message before ending a conversation with someone or giving instructions: "And don't forget, you need to make sure that you..." is often said in these circumstances. 4. Next, explain that we also remember information that we hear most frequently. This helps keep this information in our minds. This is why we remember things that we come in contact with every day, such as work procedures, names of people we see regularly, etc. 5. The third principle concerns the impact of what we hear on our remembering something. The significance of the impact that something has on us causes us to remember it. The greater the impact, the longer we remember. Think about famous lines from movies that you remember for years, even decades. We remember these famous lines because of their

impact. For example, consider the most famous line from the *Rocky* movies that began in the 1970s. Ask participants what famous line comes to mind. They will very likely tell you it was Sylvester Stallone playing the role of beaten-up Rocky Balboa, standing in the middle of the boxing ring after losing the Heavyweight Boxing Championship and screaming the name of his girlfriend: “ADRIAN!”

6. Finally explain that we remember what we have a use for. A good example is your password for your computer. A password is typically a random word and/or group of numbers that would have little or no meaning otherwise. But you remember this letter/number combination because you have to use it every day. Your social security number is another good example of something you remember because you have used it all your life. But what about driver’s license numbers? Most people don’t remember their driver’s license number because they don’t have to use it frequently. The same is true for automobile license plates. Ask participants how many know these two things. Then ask them how many know their social security numbers. Expect to find out that few, if any, participants know their driver’s license numbers or license plate (except for vanity plates), but just about everyone knows their social security number. This is because this is a number that you have a regular use for in your life, proving this last principle.

Debrief

Conclude the activity by suggesting that using these four Laws of Remembering can help participants become better at remembering important information. Participants can help others become better at remembering as well, using these principles when communicating with them.

Difficulty Rating

Low to medium

Variations

Ask participants for examples of each of these four Laws of Remembering from their own experience after presenting these principles using Handout 14-A.

The Laws of Remembering

- **Recently:** We remember best what we heard last.
- **Frequently:** We remember what we hear most often.
- **Impact:** We remember most the things that are presented dramatically.
- **Application:** We remember most the things we have a use for.

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15. The Laws of Forgetting

Description	This activity involves presenting to participants the Laws of Forgetting, including some of the reasons why people tend to forget.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To provide participants with factors that often influence why we forget things
Resources	Handout 15-A
Presentation	1. Present Handout 15-A to participants to introduce the Laws of Forgetting. 2. Explain that these principles help us better understand why we forget things. 3. Review each of the three points on the handout. Begin by asking participants why it is actually good that we don't remember everything that we hear. 4. The answer is that we simply can't retain all the information we receive on a daily basis. We need to forget information so that new information can be remembered—much the same way as memory in a computer. 5. When explaining the last point, ask participants what “adding things that were never said in the first place” reminds them of. The answer should be <i>rumors</i>. See Activity 44 for an exercise on rumors.
Debrief	Conclude the activity by emphasizing that forgetting information is a natural and, actually, necessary part of communications. We all need to be aware that we can only retain a certain amount of information at any given time. We need to make sure that this information is timely and accurate so that we can make decisions based on this type of quality information rather than rumor or forgotten facts.

50 Communications Activities, Icebreakers, and Exercises

Difficulty Rating

Low to medium

Variations

Ask participants to share any tips they use to keep from forgetting important things that they need to know.



The Laws of Forgetting

- We forget 50% of what we hear immediately.
- We forget 75% of what we hear within two months.
- Of the 25% we do remember, only 60% is correct, plus we add things that were never said in the first place!

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16. Meaning of Words

Description	Different definitions of the same word are presented as examples of how a single word can have multiple meanings.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To emphasize that even the same word can be interpreted and misinterpreted in many different ways. This is just another reason why effective communications is such a big challenge and often so difficult to achieve. Understanding this can help us be more aware of this challenge and better able to deal with different interpretations of words when they arise in our daily communications and interactions with others.
Resources	Handout 16-A
Presentation	1. Distribute or present Handout 16.A. 2. Review the different interpretations for the word <i>fast</i> as described in Handout 16-A. 3. Ask participants if they can think of any additional meanings or interpretations. 4. Discuss the challenge that this presents to being able to clearly communicate with others. Ask participants how this communication challenge can best be met. 5. Expect to hear suggestions that relate to telling others what your interpretation is of words or concepts that you are communicating to others. Asking others for their interpretation or understanding of certain words or concepts that might easily be misunderstood is another good communication technique.

50 Communications Activities, Icebreakers, and Exercises

Debrief

Conclude the activity by re-emphasizing that the same word can mean different things to different people. Gaining a better understanding of how people interpret or understand the meanings of words can greatly enhance the chance of clearly communicating with others.

Difficulty Rating

Low

Variations

Pick a different word and provide multiple definitions for the word from a dictionary.



Meaning of Words

The Oxford Dictionary records an average of 28 separate meanings for each of the 500 most-used words in the English language. For example, consider the word *fast* that can have the following meanings:

- A person is **fast** when he or she can run quickly.
- He or she is also **fast** if restrained and can't run at all.
- Colors are **fast** when they do not run.
- One is **fast** if he or she moves in suspect company.
- This is not quite the same thing as playing **fast** and loose.
- A racetrack is **fast** when it is in good running condition.
- A friend is **fast** when he or she is loyal.
- A watch is **fast** when it is ahead of time.
- To be **fast** asleep is to be deep in slumber.
- To be **fast** by is to be near.
- To **fast** is also to refrain from eating.
- A **fast** may be a ship's mooring line.
- Photographic film is **fast** when it is sensitive to light.
- Bacteria are **fast** when they are insensitive to antiseptics.

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17. Communications Circles

Description

This activity introduces a model showing three levels of communicating and sharing information.

Time Guideline

30 minutes

Purpose

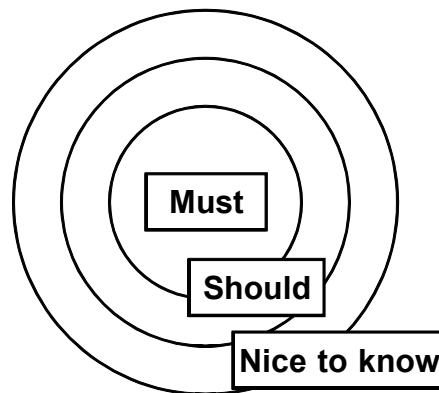
To highlight that there are different levels of sharing information and that you need to decide what level is most appropriate for any given situation

Resources

Handout 17-A

Presentation

1. Present Handout 17-A. Introduce and explain these communications circles as levels at which someone shares information. This model is particularly important for anyone in a leadership position who has access to information that his or her employees would be interested in receiving.



2. Begin explaining this model with the innermost circle labeled **must**.
3. **Must** communication is information that employees must have in order to perform their job. This level of communication is typically achieved. If not, people wouldn't be able to do their jobs. If a problem exists at this level, it typically gets corrected quickly.

4. The next level is information that an employee **should** know but doesn't have to in order to perform the job. However, receiving this information can help an employee perform better, and they also appreciate being in the "know" about this type of information. There is no guarantee that this level of communication is always achieved since employees don't have to have this information to do their jobs. This level of information may just help them perform their jobs.
5. The next circle is information that is simply **nice to know**. This communication could be on any subject and not necessarily directly or indirectly related to the job. This is simply telling people about things that may be of general interest to them but that they don't really need to know. This information could be about organizational changes, personnel announcement, business updates, or anything that may be appropriate but not necessary to share with them.
6. There is another type of information not shown on this communications model. This is information that you **can't** share. One of the most difficult communications challenges for a supervisor or manager is when employees ask about information that must remain confidential and that you consequently cannot share. Employees will be more accepting that there is certain information that they shouldn't know if the other communications levels from the model have been achieved. Simply telling employees that the information is confidential will be much better accepted if you have built communication trust by sharing whatever information you can with them.
7. In these circumstances, instruct participants that if an employee asks a question about a confidential topic, it is best to simply explain that you have been told not to discuss that topic. Employees will accept this and respect the need for confidentiality.

Debrief

As discussed during this activity, by sharing information at all three levels of the model, you build greater communications trust with employees who report to you. Employees have a strong desire to receive communications on all three levels of this model. Emphasize in closing just how important these levels of communications can be to everyone in the organization.

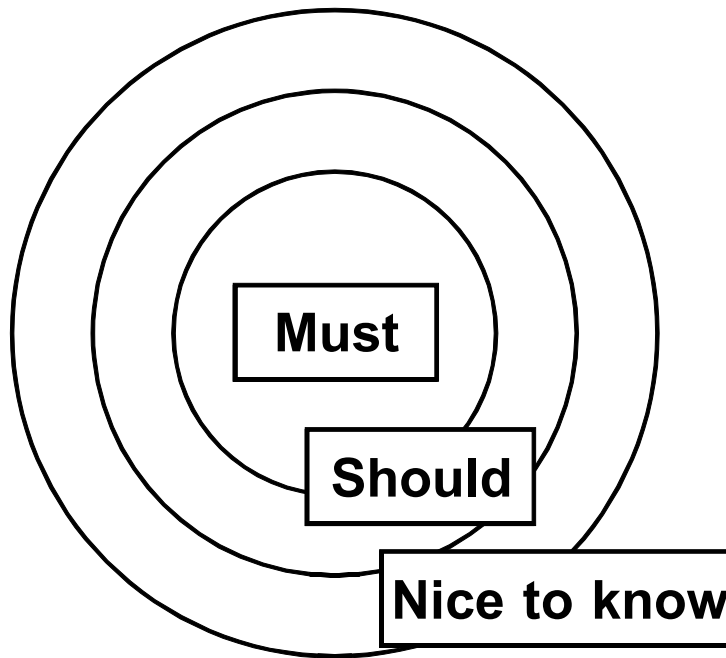
Difficulty Rating

Medium to high

Variations

Ask participants to evaluate themselves concerning what level on this communications model they share information with others, particularly employees who report to them. Challenge participants to think about how they can move to a higher level (toward **nice to know**) of communications on this model.

Communications Circles



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18. Attention Spans

Description	The average attention spans of high school students and adults are presented.
Time Guideline	20 minutes
Purpose	To help participants better understand just how limited attention spans can be and the challenge this presents in communications
Resources	Handout 18-A
Presentation	1. Begin the activity by asking participants what they think is meant by “attention span” as it relates to communications. You should expect to hear replies that relate to how long someone can concentrate on one thing before becoming distracted in some way. 2. Distribute or present Handout 18-A. 3. Read what the attention span is of a high school student and ask participants if they agree or disagree with this assessment. 4. Next read what the attention span is of the average adult. Again ask participants if they agree or disagree. 5. To prove this point, read the following brief passage to participants and ask them to raise their hand (and leave it up) when they begin to lose their attention to what you are reading.

Building a Simple Crystal Radio

A crystal radio is the distilled essence of a radio. It has very few parts, it needs no batteries or other power source, and it can be built in a short time out of things you can find around the house.

The reason a crystal radio does not need any batteries is the amazing capabilities of the human ear. The ear is extremely sensitive

to very faint sounds. The crystal radio uses only the energy of the radio waves sent by radio transmitters. These radio transmitters send out enormous amounts of energy (tens of thousands of watts). However, because they are usually far away, and we have at most a few hundred feet of wire for an antenna, the amount of energy we receive with the crystal radio is measured in billionths of a watt. The human ear can detect sounds that are less than a millionth of even that.

6. After reading this passage, see how many participants have raised their hands and tell them they can now put their hands down.
7. Ask those who acknowledged losing their attention what happened. Expect to hear answers that relate to the participant beginning to think about other things while listening to the passage, daydreaming, being bored with the content of the passage, etc. Also expect to hear responses from some participants that they were very interested in the information being shared and were paying close, undistracted attention. This shows that if you are interested in something, your attention span will be longer.

Debrief

Conclude the activity by emphasizing the point that if you want to keep the attention of others, you need to communicate about subjects that they are interested in hearing and discussing.

Difficulty Rating

Low

Variations

Read a passage of your own or one that relates to the participants' workplace instead of the one provided.



Attention Spans

- The average attention span of a high school student is about 10 seconds.
- For an adult it is longer—about 17 seconds!

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19. Meaning of Listening

Description	The Chinese word for listening is presented, and its meaning is discussed.
Time Guideline	15 minutes
Purpose	To share how the components of the Chinese word for listening are broken down and how they help us better understand what listening really means
Resources	Handout 19-A
Presentation	1. Distribute or present Handout 19-A. 2. Explain that this is the Chinese word for listening. 3. Review each of the components of this word in Chinese as presented in the handout. 4. Explain how each one is critically important for listening to occur. 5. First listening requires the ear. If we don't or aren't able to hear, then listening can't take place. Your ears are primary to listening. In other words, we must give the other person communicating our full attention so that we actually hear the message. 6. We also must listen with our eyes. Much of listening is observing and trying to understand not only <i>what</i> is being said but <i>how</i> it is being said. This is often called nonverbal communications. 7. Explain that listening also involves the heart. We need to understand the emotion that is being communicated in the words we hear (and see). 8. Review the summary on the handout: Listening requires ears as primary, plus eye contact, and one heart. . .a full attention.

Debrief

Reflect that studying the Chinese word for listening serves as an excellent model for understanding what is needed to be a good listener. If we listen with not only our ears but also our eyes and hearts with our full attention, we can learn to become better listeners. Ask participants how they can use these lessons from the Chinese word for listening to help them become better listeners.

Difficulty Rating

Medium

Variations

Ask participants if they have thoughts of any other interpretations they may see for the Chinese word for listening.

Listening =

聽

耳
占

... ear

...king ...primary

...add ...plus

目

...eye ...eye contact

...one

心

...heart

Listening requires ears as primary, plus eye contact, and one heart. . .a full attention.

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20. Vanity Name Tent Cards

Description

This activity is designed to be an icebreaker exercise to help introduce participants to one another. Participants are asked to draw on their name tent card pictures, symbols, words, etc., that describe themselves.

Time Guideline

10 to 20 minutes, depending on the number of participants

Purpose

To help introduce participants to one another and make everyone feel more comfortable before the meeting, seminar, training program, etc., begins

Resources

A name tent card printed on heavy card stock for each participant

Colored markers

Presentation

1. Make sure that each participant is provided a name tent card with his or her name pre-printed on it. If not, ask participants to write their names on their tent cards.
2. Distribute colored markers to participants.
3. Instruct participants to draw or write information about themselves on their name tent cards to personalize them and share some information about themselves with the group.
4. To help explain what participants are being asked to do, compare their name tent cards to vanity license plates, but with more options for pictures and colors.
5. As an example, you might draw your own vanity name tent card to help participants think about how they can design their own. An example might be:

PETER

Married w/ 2kids&1dog-vacationsinNC

50 Communications Activities, Icebreakers, and Exercises

6. Once everyone has completed their name tent cards, ask each participant to briefly explain what he or she drew or wrote on his or her card. In the example above, Peter would explain that he is married and his wife's name is Nancy, they have two children Lauren and Erin, they have a pet dog (a West Highland White Terrier) named Christy, and they enjoy going together on summer vacations to the beach in North Carolina.

Debrief

After participants have finished introducing their vanity name tent cards, thank them for sharing this information with the group and explain that this information will be helpful for everyone to get to know one another a little better before starting the meeting, seminar, training program, etc.

Difficulty Rating

Low

Variations

Ask participants to vote on the most creative vanity name tent card.



21. Repeating Introductions

Description

In this activity, each participant shares three things about himself or herself, then repeats three things the other participants have shared previously about themselves.

Time Guideline

Depends on the number of participants; be aware that this activity can take over 30 minutes from beginning to end for a typical group of 20 to 30 participants

Purpose

To serve as an icebreaker before the beginning of a seminar, training program, meeting, etc.

Resources

None required

Presentation

1. Introduce the activity as an icebreaker to help participants get to know one another.
2. Explain that each participant is going to be asked to share the following information about himself or herself with the group:
 - Their name
 - Their hobby or favorite pastime
 - Where they would really like to be at the moment
3. Ask for a volunteer to begin this activity, sharing these three things about himself or herself.
4. Next ask another participant to share these same three things about himself or herself and the three things that were shared by the previous participant.
5. Continue this activity with the current participant sharing these three things about himself or herself, then those things shared by each previous participant, until everyone has had a turn. Keep in mind that the list of things that every successive participant must remember will continue to keep growing.

6. Allow the group to help participants if they need assistance remembering everything shared about previous participants. If a participant appears embarrassed or overly anxious about being able to remember all of this information in front of the group, allow these individuals the option of not participating.

Debrief

After everyone has had a chance to repeat the introductions of everyone else, ask participants to share their thoughts about this exercise. Expect to hear comments about how difficult it was to remember everyone's information. Ask participants how carefully they listened, especially before their turn. You will undoubtedly hear participants say that they listened very intently because they knew they were going to be called on to repeat this information. Suggest that this activity is a good example of how you help others be better listeners by giving them a listening assignment that they know they will have to complete. Before you end this activity, explain that participants will likely remember this information about each other for a long time.

Difficulty Rating

High

Variations

If the group is large, break participants into smaller, more manageable groups to help this activity go faster.



22. Circle, Square, Triangle, or Z

Description

This activity is an icebreaker to help get participants talking about themselves from the start of a seminar, training program, or meeting.

Time Guideline

20 to 30 minutes, depending on the number of participants

Purpose

To allow participants to share a little about themselves with the group as part of the introductions to one another

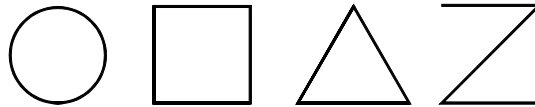
Resources

Flip chart or white board and markers for participants

Tent cards with participants' names

Presentation

1. Explain that this activity is designed to help participants learn more about one another.
2. On a writing surface, draw the following:



3. Ask each participant to draw one of these shapes on their name tent card. Tell them to pick whatever shape appeals to them the most and that they think best represents them. Provide markers so that these shapes can clearly be seen.
4. After everyone has completed marking their name tent cards, ask each participant to explain why he or she chose the shape he or she did.
5. After everyone has had a chance to discuss their name tent cards, explain the following:

50 Communications Activities, Icebreakers, and Exercises

Research has shown that

- a) those who marked their cards with a Z are the most creative in the group;
- b) those who marked their cards with a triangle are the most intelligent in the group;
- c) those who marked their cards with a square are the most ambitious in the group and will make it to the top; and
- d) those who marked their cards with a circle are the “party animals” in the group!

Debrief

Have some fun with this activity, especially the explanation for those with circles. Remember that these symbols will remain visible on participants’ cards throughout the program, and humorous comments can be made about these designations to help make the program fun.

Difficulty Rating

Medium

Variations

To save time, only have participants mark their name tent cards with a symbol without explaining why they chose the shape they did, but still share what each symbol represents.



23. Introducing Each Other

Description	Participants are asked to break up into pairs to learn about each other in order to briefly introduce the other person to the group.
Time Guideline	20 to 30 minutes, depending on the number of participants
Purpose	To serve as both an icebreaker and a way for participants to learn more about one another
Resources	None required
Presentation	1. After welcoming participants to the seminar, training program, meeting, etc., tell them that they are going to introduce one another to the group. 2. Break participants into pairs by asking each person to work with the person sitting next to him or her. To alleviate confusion, you could assign these pairs and, if there is an odd number, break the last group into a triad. 3. Instruct participants to spend a few moments learning about the other individual in order to introduce that person to the rest of the group. Suggest that each person learn something about the other person that the group (if familiar with one another) might not already know, such as the person's hobbies, vacation destinations, age of children, schooling, special skills or training, etc. 4. After each pair has had enough time to learn about each other (monitor each pair's discussions by walking around to check if they are still interviewing each other), ask each person to introduce the other to the entire group. Explain that these introductions should be brief—only a minute or two.

50 Communications Activities, Icebreakers, and Exercises

Debrief

Thank participants for their introductions of one another and begin the seminar, training program, or meeting.

Difficulty Rating

Low to medium

Variations

Give specific questions that each person should ask of the other, such as favorite part of his or her job, a funny experience he or she may have had in his or her career, most embarrassing moment at work, etc.



24. Fantasy Career

Description	Participants are asked what their fantasy career would be if they could have any job they wanted.
Time Guideline	20 to 30 minutes, depending on the number of participants
Purpose	To serve as an icebreaker activity and provide an opportunity for participants to share information about themselves with one another
Resources	None required
Presentation	1. As an introduction to one another, ask each participant to share with the group what his or her fantasy career would be if he or she could do anything for a living. 2. Allow each participant to briefly explain what this occupation, trade, or job might be. 3. As participants share this information, occasionally ask clarifying questions about these fantasy careers, such as if the participant has ever done anything like this in the past or why he or she is interested.
Debrief	After everyone has explained their fantasy career, thank them for sharing this with the group and emphasize how learning a little more about one another will be helpful during the seminar, training program, or meeting that you are about to begin.
Difficulty Rating	Low to medium
Variations	Also ask participants what would be the opposite of their fantasy career—in other words, their nightmare career.



25. Name that Participant

Description	Each participant is asked to complete a questionnaire about himself or herself and then hand it in to the facilitator. The group is then asked to guess who the respondent is of each questionnaire that is read aloud by the facilitator. (This activity works best when participants already know or are familiar with one another.)
Time Guideline	30 minutes or longer, depending on the number of participants
Purpose	To provide a different and participative way for participants to get to know one another better
Resources	Handout 25-A
Presentation	1. Distribute Handout 25-A to participants. 2. Explain that each participant should complete the questionnaire without sharing his or her answers with others. 3. After collecting the completed questionnaires, select one at random without revealing the participant's name. 4. Read the questions and answers, and ask the group to identify the participant. 5. Allow some brief discussion and speculation as to who the respondent is of each questionnaire. 6. Ask the respondent of each questionnaire to finally identify himself or herself.
Debrief	Thank participants for sharing this information about themselves and begin the seminar, training program, or meeting.
Difficulty Rating	Medium to high

Variations

Instead of revealing all of the questionnaires at one time, read one at a time throughout the program or seminar to serve as a refresher moment throughout the day or save them until a group dinner at the end of the day.